

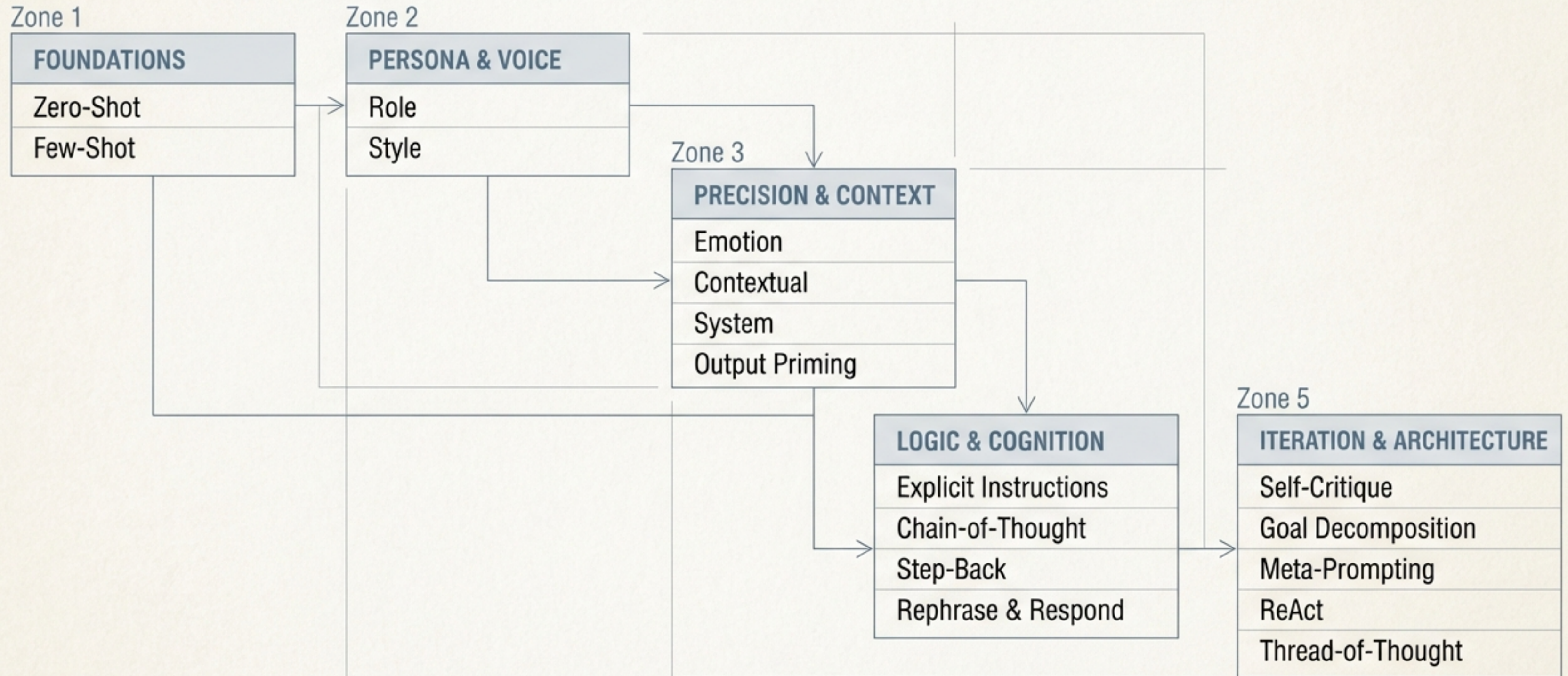
THE 17 PROTOCOLS OF PROMPT ENGINEERING

Engineering reliable, high-fidelity outputs from Large Language Models.



ARCHITECTURAL MASTER PLAN // REFERENCE GUIDE

THE ARCHITECT'S TAXONOMY: STRUCTURING THE 17 PROTOCOLS



KEY TAKEAWAY: Stop treating Large Language Models like search engines. Treat them like execution engines requiring precise parameters.

01. Zero-Shot Prompting

Ask the model to perform a task or answer a question directly, without providing any prior examples. Ideal for simple tasks where the LLM has sufficient general understanding.

Example 1 (Source)	Example 2 (Context A)	Example 3 (Context B)
Before: "What is photosynthesis?" After: "Explain photosynthesis to a <u>5-year-old child.</u> "	Before: "Summarise this transcript." After: "Summarise this meeting transcript into <u>five actionable bullet points.</u> "	Before: "Translate to French." After: "Translate the phrase 'Hello, how are you?' into <u>formal Parisian French.</u> "

02. Few-Shot Prompting

Provide a few examples (input/output pairs) to demonstrate the exact desired task and formatting constraints before the actual query.

Example 1 (Source)	Example 2 (Context A)	Example 3 (Context B)
Input: <u>"Text: I loved it! -> Sentiment: Positive"</u> before asking to classify <u>"The movie was okay."</u>	Input: Providing <u>two examples extracting just the company name from a news headline, before proving the target headline.</u>	Input: Demonstrating the conversion of "March 4th, 2023" to <u>"2023-03-04"</u> <u>twice before providing the target date.</u>

Protocol Set 02: Persona & Voice

03. Role Prompting

Definition

Instruct the LLM to adopt a specific persona, character, or professional background to alter its vocabulary, depth, and explanatory analogies.

Panel 1 (Source)

You are **Professor Astra**, a friendly and slightly eccentric astronomer... tell me about black holes.

Panel 2 (Orig A)

Act as a **strictly objective, senior DevOps engineer**... review this code.

Panel 3 (Orig B)

You are a **cynical 1920s noir detective**... explain this missing file error.

04. Style Prompting

Definition

Guide the LLM to write in a particular literary, artistic, formal, or informal style, enforcing rigid stylistic constraints.

Panel 1 (Source)

Write a short description of a sunset in the style of a **haiku**.

Panel 2 (Orig A)

Write our quarterly financial report summary in the style of an **18th-century pirate captain**.

Panel 3 (Orig B)

Draft a meeting decline email in the style of **Shakespearean iambic pentameter**.

Protocol Set 03: Emotional Resonance & Context

05. Emotion Prompting

Explicitly instruct the LLM to generate a response from a specific emotional perspective, adding depth or specific sentiment.

Write a thank you note for a gift... Make it sound **very excited and deeply grateful**.

Draft an apology email to a client for a service outage. Make the tone sound **genuinely remorseful and highly urgent**.

Write a product launch announcement. Make the tone sound **intensely urgent and boundary-pushing**.

06. Contextual Prompting

Provide the LLM with comprehensive background information, history, preferences, or constraints relevant to the request to ensure hyper-tailored outputs.

Providing **recipient age, occasion, specific interests, and exact budget** before asking for a gift suggestion.

Listing **three specific dietary restrictions, prep-time limits, and current pantry inventory** before asking for a dinner recipe.

Providing the **legacy tech stack, target cloud environment, and compliance requirements** before asking for a software migration plan.

Protocol Set 04: Formatting & Constraints

07. System Prompting

Provide high-level, persistent instructions in the 'system message' to dictate overall goals, constraints, or behaviour across an entire session.

System:	System:	System:
You are a 'Concise Summariser'. Your primary goal is to provide the shortest possible summary... aim for just one clear sentence.	You are a strict data formatter. You will only ever output valid, minified JSON. You will never output conversational text.	You are a direct translation engine. Output only the target language string. Do not include pleasantries.

08. Output Priming

Provide the LLM with the exact beginning of its desired response, forcefully nudging it into a specific structure, format, or tone.

Prompt ends with: "Here are the ingredients for a simple vanilla cake: - '	Prompt ends with: "The three primary socio-economic causes of the French Revolution were: 1."	Prompt ends with: ```python def calculate_fibonacci(n): `'
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Protocol Set 05: Absolute Clarity

09. Explicit Instructions Prompting

Be crystal clear and unambiguous in requests. Detail exact format, length, necessary inclusions, and critical exclusions.

Block 1	
Write a short paragraph about apples... exactly 3 sentences long. Mention at least two varieties. DO NOT discuss apple cultivation or history.	
Block 2	
Write a marketing email. Under 100 words. DO NOT use any emojis. You MUST include a call-to-action hyperlink.	
Block 3	
Review this code snippet. ONLY comment on security vulnerabilities. ENTIRELY IGNORE formatting or style guidelines.	

10. Rephrase and Respond (RaR)

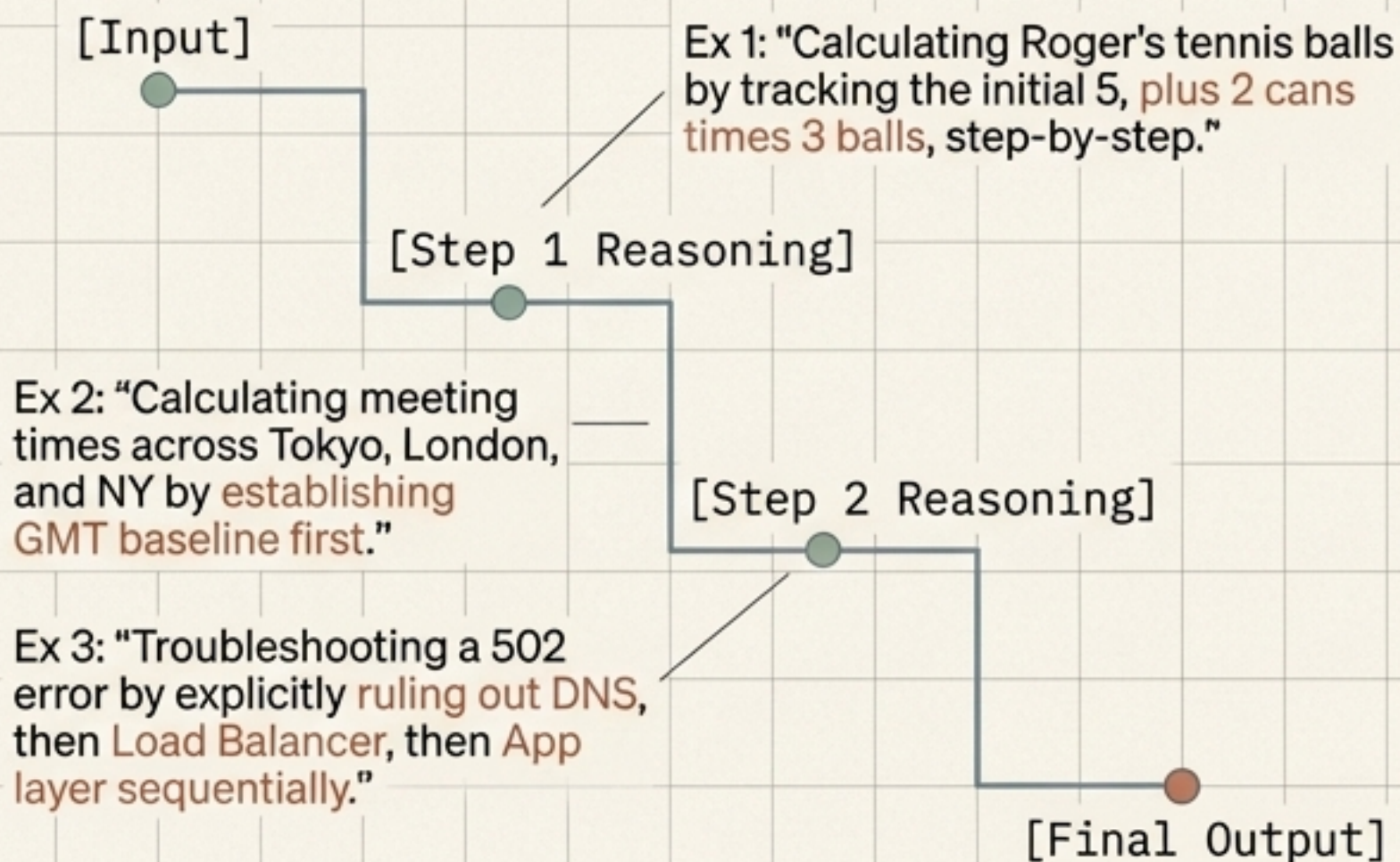
Ask the LLM to first rephrase the request or explain its understanding of the task parameters before generating the final response.

Block 1	
Step 1: First... Step 2: Then... First, briefly describe what kind of journey you are planning to write about... Then, write a short story based on your description.	
Block 2	
Step 1: First... Step 2: Then... First, outline the three primary constraints of quantum computing we must address. Then, write the explanation.	
Block 3	
Step 1: First... Step 2: Then... First, list the key legal risks involved in this scenario. Then, draft the sensitive HR policy addressing them.	

Protocol Set 06: Inducing Logic

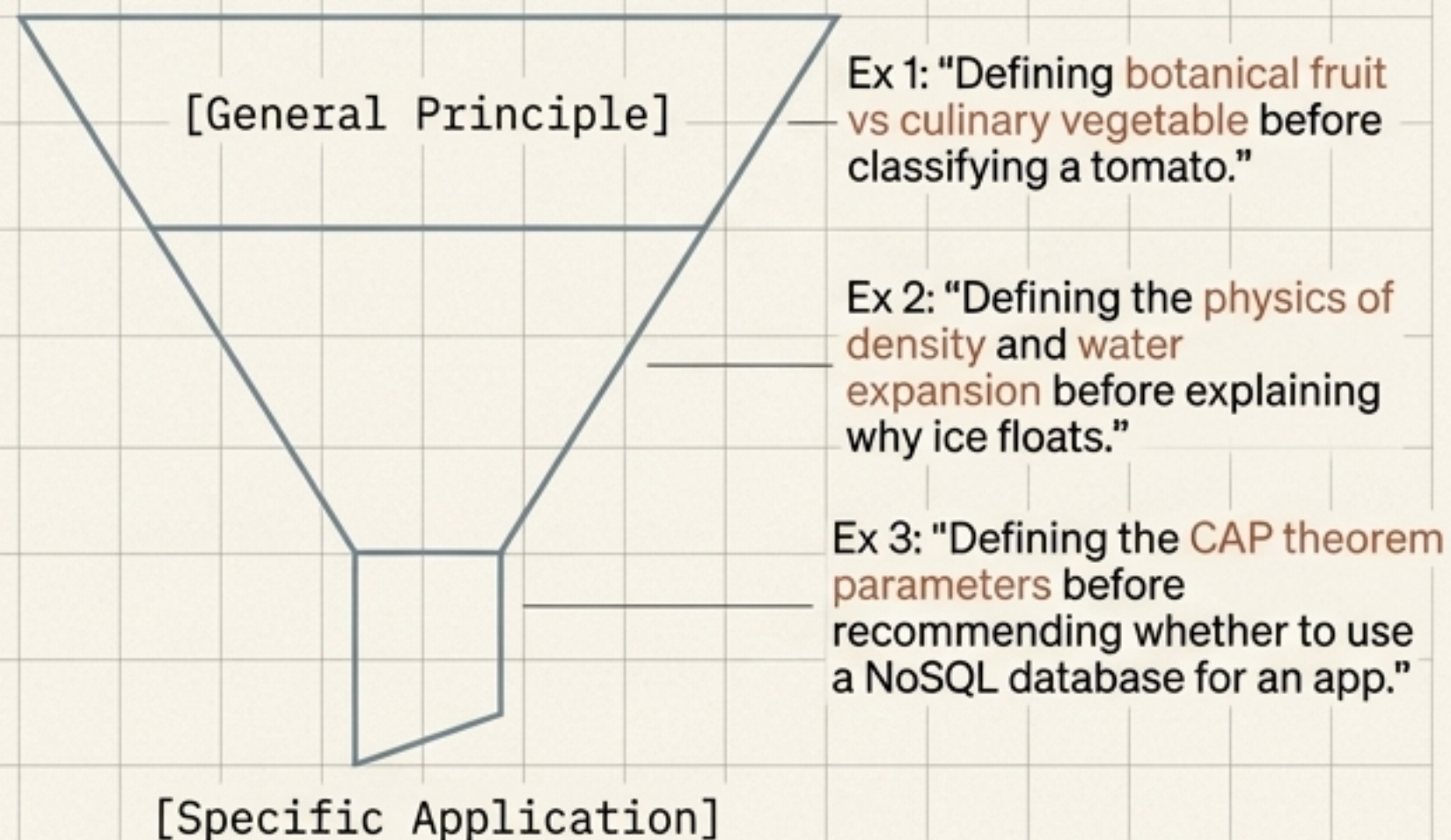
11. Chain-of-Thought (CoT)

Encourage the LLM to "think step by step" or show its work, essential for multi-step reasoning and mathematics.



12. Step-Back Prompting

Guide the LLM to first consider broader foundational concepts or principles before attempting to answer a specific, nuanced question.



Protocol Set 07: Structured Refinement

13. Self-Critique & Refinement

Instruct the LLM to generate an initial response, critically evaluate it against specific criteria, and then output a revised version.

1. Generate initial slogan. → 2. Critically evaluate... Is it catchy? → 3. Based on critique, output improved slogan.

1. Draft cold sales email. → 2. Critique specifically for brevity and presumptuousness. → 3. Rewrite email.

1. Write Python parsing script. → 2. Self-evaluate for unhandled edge cases. → 3. Output hardened code.

14. Goal Decomposition Prompting

Break down a large, complex task into smaller, numbered sub-goals within the prompt to ensure all components are addressed sequentially.

1. Planning a trip:

1. Spot type
2. Pack list
3. Activities
4. Safety tip

2. Structuring marketing:

1. Target Audience Persona
2. Acquisition Channels
3. Budget Allocation

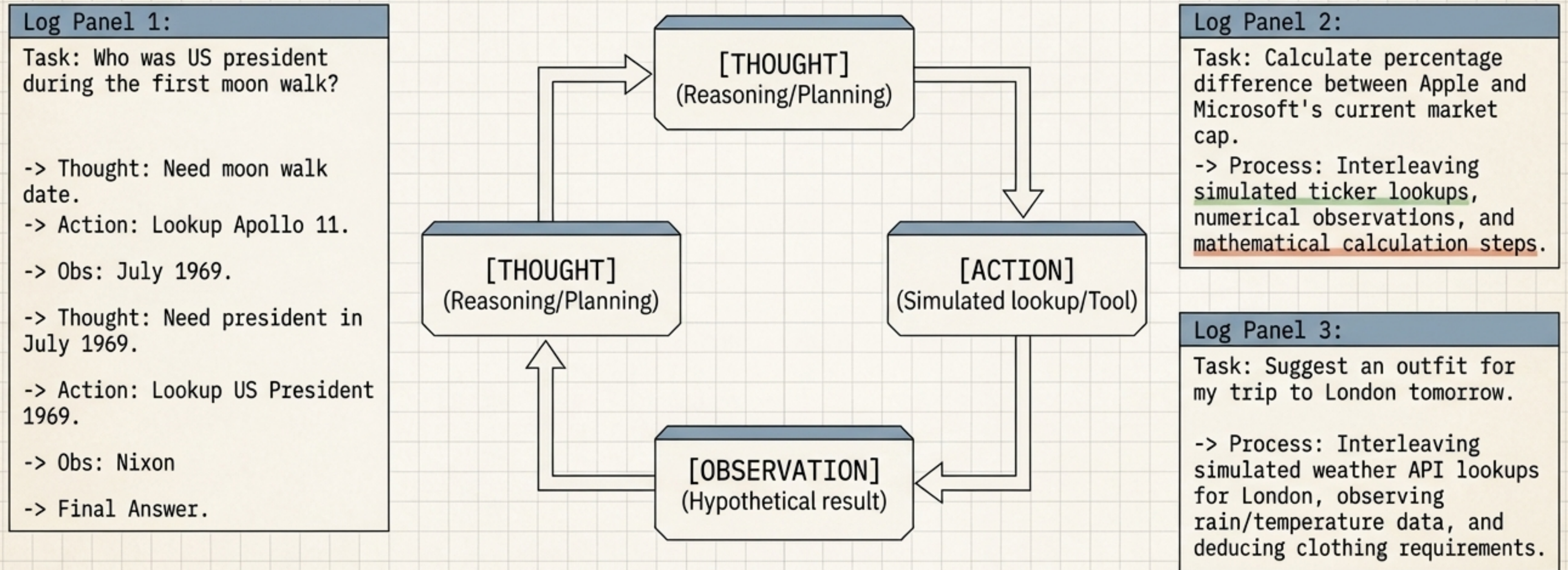
3. New hire onboarding:

1. IT provisioning
2. Key stakeholder meetings
3. Day-one deliverables

Protocol Set 08: The LLM as an Agent

15. Central Concept: ReAct (Reason + Act)

Enable LLMs to solve complex tasks by interleaving **reasoning** (breaking down the problem) with **acting** (simulating information gathering or tool use).



Protocol Set 09: Sustained Architecture

16. Meta-Prompting

Use the LLM to engineer better prompts for another (or the same) LLM. Describe the goal and ask the LLM to write the optimal prompt.

Example 1: Fantasy Prompt Generation

Ask LLM to write a highly detailed prompt that will generate **3 distinct fantasy story ideas** with **specific character and conflict** constraints.

Example 2: Workout Plan System Prompt

Ask LLM to generate **the perfect system prompt** for a chatbot designed to provide rigorous, scientifically backed workout plans.

Example 3: Adversarial Role-Play Setup

Ask LLM to write a comprehensive prompt setting up a **highly adversarial role-playing scenario** for executive negotiation training.

17. Thread-of-Thought (ThoT)

Provide a structured outline and explicitly instruct the LLM to maintain a coherent narrative and logical flow across a long piece of generated text.

Example 1: US Bill to Law Process

Explaining how a US bill becomes law, explicitly demanding transition phrases linking the **introduction → committee stage → final vote**.

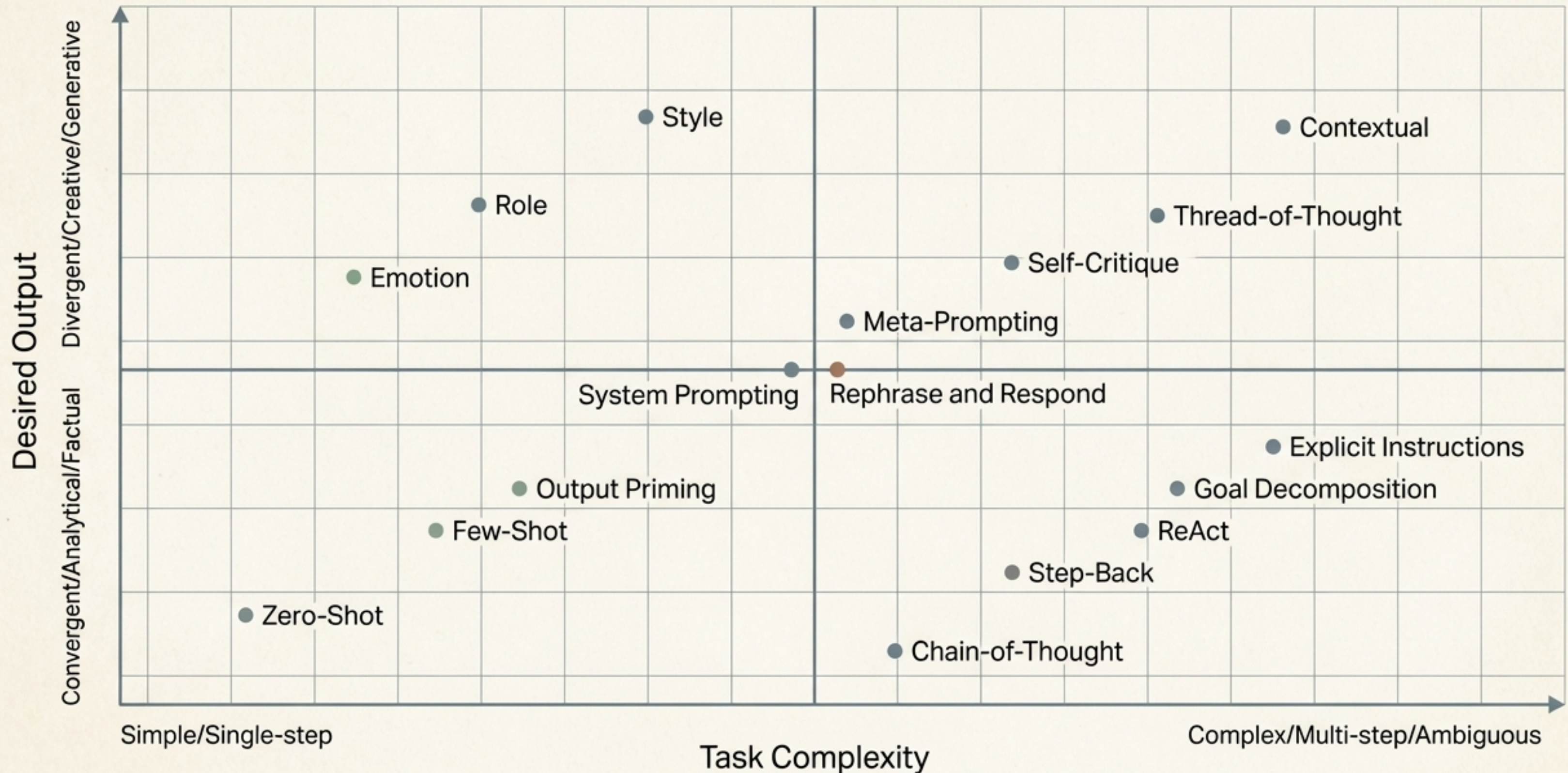
Example 2: AI Regulations Whitepaper

Writing a whitepaper on AI regulations, ensuring the logical thread connects **technical definitions → directly to policy recommendations**.

Example 3: Microservices Debugging Guide

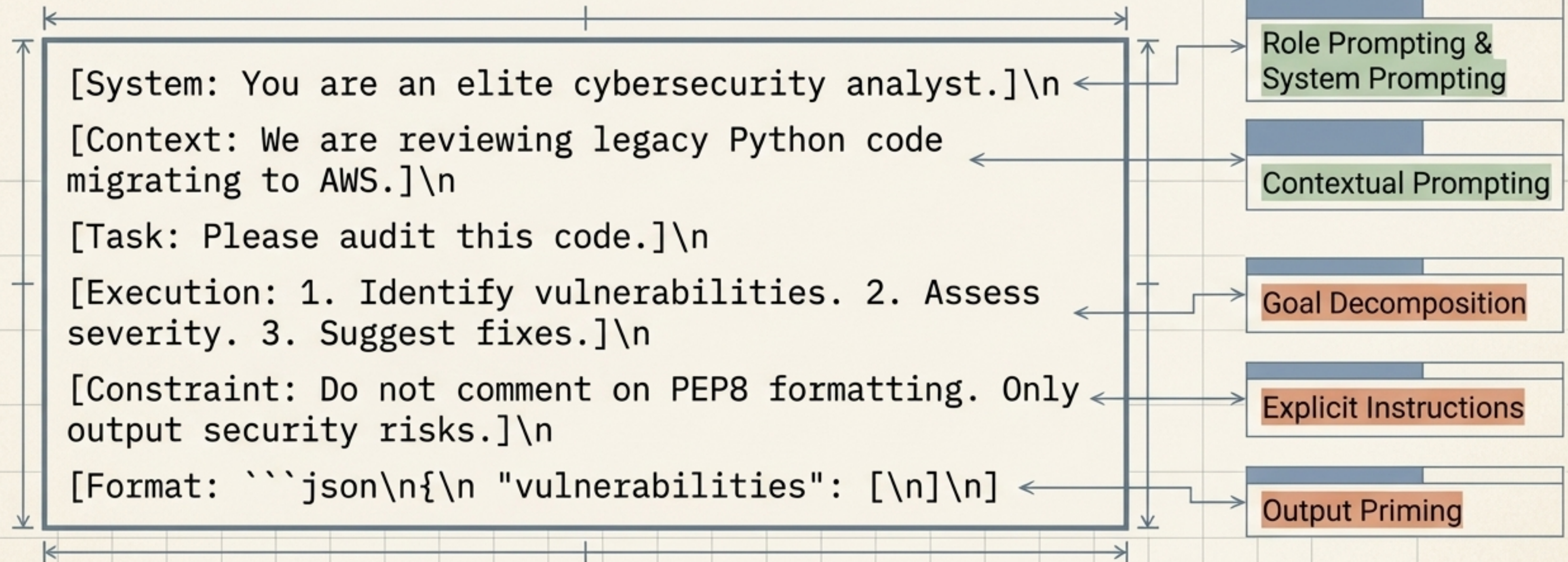
Documenting microservices debugging, tracing logic sequentially from the **API gateway → down to the database timeout**.

The Diagnostic Matrix: Deployment Strategy



Compiling the Master Prompt

“Mastery is not using one technique; it is stacking constraints until the LLM has no choice but to produce the exact desired output.”



Operating Axioms for the Code-Space

1

Axiom 1: Default to Zero Trust.

Assume the LLM will take the path of least resistance. Enforce boundaries using Explicit Instructions and System Prompts before executing.

2

Axiom 2: Force the Cognitive Step.

For any complex task, never allow immediate answers. Always inject Chain-of-Thought, Step-Back, or ReAct constraints to make the reasoning visible.

3

Axiom 3: Architecture Over Iteration.

Stop endlessly tweaking vague prompts. Break the problem down using Goal Decomposition and Meta-Prompting. Engineer the request, don't just ask the question.